Cohort: product requirements document

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Cohort is a community app for CA, CMA and CS students in India: one place for the daily feed of posts and announcements, subject-wise study resources, articleship and job hunting, groups and personal messaging, plus an ICAI services module with an AI study assistant and MCQ practice. This PRD covers the full product: who it serves, every feature with user stories and acceptance criteria, non-functional requirements, monetization options and a phased roadmap. It matches the clickable prototype, screen for screen.

1. Vision and problem

> **One app where a CA, CMA or CS student spends their study day: read, revise, ask, apply, connect.**

India has over a million active CA, CMA and CS students. Their daily workflow today is scattered: ICAI announcements on one website, notes in Telegram and Drive folders, articleship openings on WhatsApp groups and LinkedIn, doubts in coaching groups, and mock tests inside separate apps. Nothing ties the student community together, and nothing is built around the three courses sharing one structure (Foundation, Inter, Final).

Cohort puts the whole student life in one app. The morning starts with the Top 10 reads for today, a curated daily document of what a student or mentor should read. The community feeds posts, announcements and mentor broadcasts. Resources are organized exactly the way the courses are. Work and hiring covers articleships, jobs, gig work and industrial training. The ICAI module brings institute services, an AI study assistant and MCQ practice into the same app, and personal messaging connects students with mentors and firms.

Working name	Cohort (placeholder until a final name is picked)
Platforms	Android, iOS and web, from one codebase
Market	India: ICAI, ICMAI and ICSI students and members
Companion docs	App flows and technical design, separate Files

2. Who it serves

1. **Students (primary)**
   CA, CMA and CS students at Foundation, Inter and Final, plus aspirants. They want organized resources, timely announcements, answers to doubts, practice questions and articleship or job leads.

2. **Mentors and qualified professionals**
   Practising CAs, CMAs and CSs, rankers and seniors who guide students, run revision sessions and answer doubts. Verified, so students know the advice is real.

3. **Firms and recruiters**
   CA firms and companies posting articleships, industrial training, gig work and jobs. They get reach into exactly the student pool they hire from.

4. **Moderators (internal)**
   The Cohort team: pins official announcements, reviews reports, verifies professionals and firms, and keeps the feed clean.

3. Goals and success metrics

Targets for the first six months after public launch. Numbers are goals to agree on, not commitments.

	Target 1
Activation: new signups who pick a course and level	70%
Day-30 retention of activated students	35%
Weekly active students opening the daily reads	40% of WAU
Resources downloaded per active student per month	5+
Applications submitted through Work and hiring	500+
AI assistant sessions per week	3,000+
MCQ attempts completed per week	5,000+

4. Feature requirements

Every feature below exists in the clickable prototype. Stories are written from the user's point of view; acceptance criteria are testable. IDs are stable handles for development tickets.

4.1 Feed (home)

F-1 Top 10 reads for today

As a student or mentor, I see a curated list of the 10 things worth reading today (ICAI announcements, tax updates, quick revisions, exam tips, amendments, case law, mentor notes, career advice, routines), presented like a beautiful document I can flip through.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- A document-style card appears at the top of the Feed every day, with a PDF-style badge, date and stacked-pages visual.
- The card flips through the 10 reads one at a time with a slide animation, dots and previous/next controls.
- Tapping a read opens the full document view listing all 10 numbered items; Close returns to the Feed.
- Content refreshes every morning; each read shows its type, estimated minutes and a short summary.

F-2 Unified feed of posts, announcements and broadcasts

As a student, I scroll one feed that mixes community posts, official announcements and mentor broadcasts, so I never miss anything.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- Feed items show author avatar, name, role pill (CA Final, Mentor, Official...), time, text, likes and comments.
- Official announcements can be pinned to the top with a pinned label.
- Filter chips (All, Posts, Announcements, Messages) filter the feed without reloading.
- A time-based greeting shows the user's first name and today's date.

F-3 Create anything from the + button

As any user, I tap the floating + button and get one menu with everything I can create: a post, a group, a job opening, a new message or a shared resource.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- The + button floats bottom-right above the tab bar on every screen, smaller than a standard FAB (42px).
- It auto-hides while the user scrolls through content and reappears when scrolling stops or reverses; it stays hidden on Resources, while the AI chat card is on screen, and while typing in the AI composer.
- Tapping opens a bottom sheet with five actions: Create a post, Create a group, Post a job opening, New message, Share a resource.
- Each action opens a simple form and ends in a success state; New message navigates to Messages.
- The + rotates into a close icon while the sheet is open; a scrim tap closes the sheet.

4.2 Resources

R-1 Course-structured library

As a CMA Inter student, I drill down CMA, then Inter, then a group, then a subject, and see exactly the materials for that subject.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- Three course segments (CA, CMA, CS), each with its own level names (CA: Foundation, Inter, Final; CMA: Foundation, Inter, Final; CS: Foundation, Executive, Professional).
- Each level shows its group structure and subjects exactly as the institute defines them.
- Each subject expands to show resources grouped by type: Notes, Question papers, Videos, RTP and MTP.
- Type filter chips (All, Notes, Question papers, Videos, RTP and MTP) narrow what each subject shows.

R-2 Search, download and share

As a student, I search for a topic, download what I need, and share my own notes back to the community.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- A search bar accepts subject and topic queries and returns matching resources across courses.
- Each resource shows format, size or length, author and download count, with a download button.
- Share a resource from the + menu adds it to the right subject with title and course/subject tags.
- Downloaded files are available offline inside the app.

4.3 Community

C-1 My groups and Discover

As a student, I manage the groups I belong to and discover new ones: study circles, exam-form help groups and professional groups.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- The Community tab shows two views only: My groups and Discover. There is no separate Create Group button on this tab.
- Group cards show name, description, purpose pill (Study group, Exam form, Professional) and member count.
- Join and Joined toggle membership immediately and update the member count.
- New groups are created only from the + menu; the empty state says so.

C-2 Create a group

As a student, I create a group for my study circle in two fields from the + menu.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- The create-group form asks for a group name and purpose.
- On submit, the creator becomes the admin and the group appears in My groups.
- Group purpose choices match the group types: study circle, exam form, professional.

4.4 Work and hiring

W-1 Vacancy scan

As a CA Inter student, the app scans new openings and tells me how many match my profile this week.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- A vacancy scan banner summarizes new matching openings per week for the user's course and level.
- Matching uses the profile (course, level, city preference) and improves as the profile fills in.
- The scan runs on a schedule and triggers a notification when strong matches appear.

W-2 Browse and apply

As a student, I filter openings by Articleship, Jobs, Gig work or Industrial training, and apply in one tap.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- Job cards show role, firm or company, location, pay (stipend or LPA), tags and category.
- Filter chips cover All, Articleship, Jobs, Gig work, Industrial training.
- Apply changes to an Applied state immediately and sends the application with the student profile attached.
- The firm sees the application in its inbox and the student gets status updates in Messages.

W-3 Post a job opening (firms)

As a firm, I post an opening from the + menu and it goes live under Work and hiring.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- The form captures role and firm or company; category, location, pay and tags follow in the full form.
- Only verified firm accounts can publish openings.
- Posted openings appear in the Work feed and in vacancy-scan matching.

4.5 ICAI module

I-1 ICAI services in one grid

As a student, I reach every ICAI service (exam form, admit card, results, announcements, study material, SSP portal, syllabus, mock tests, RTP and MTP, important dates, articleship, membership, exam centres, helpdesk) without hunting across websites.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- A 14-tile grid covers the services listed in the prototype, each with an icon and a one-line subtitle.
- Tapping a tile opens the service inside the app or deep-links to the official ICAI page.
- The grid also represents ICMAI and ICSI services when the user's course is CMA or CS.

I-2 AI study assistant (Cohort AI)

As a student, I ask the AI to summarize a topic, clear a concept or draft a revision plan, and its answers appear as a friendly study bot.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- The assistant has a visible bot identity: bot avatar, the name Cohort AI and an online status line.
- Quick chips offer common asks (summarize a standard, explain a concept, build a revision plan); free-text questions work too.
- AI replies carry the bot avatar; the user's own messages look distinct.
- Answers are study-scoped, concise and exam-oriented; the AI declines non-study requests politely.

I-3 MCQ practice

As a CA Final student, I practice MCQs by subject, get instant right or wrong feedback with the correct answer, and see my score at the end.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- A practice set shows the course and subject pill, question count and progress (Q1 of 3).
- Selecting an option locks it, marks correct in green and wrong in red, and reveals the right answer.
- The end state shows the score with encouragement and a restart button.
- Attempts are saved to a history so progress is trackable over time.

I-4 Connections network

As a student, I find and connect with fellow students, mentors, practising CAs and firms from one list.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- People cards show name, role line and kind (Mentor, Firm, Peer).
- Connect sends a request and shows a Requested state until accepted.
- Qualified professionals and firms carry verified badges once approved by moderators.

4.6 Messages

M-1 Personal messaging

As a student, I message fellow students, mentors and firms one-to-one from the top-right icon, reachable from every screen.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- The conversation list shows avatar, name, latest message preview and an unread count badge.
- Opening a thread shows the full history with clear bubbles for each side and a composer.
- The header message icon shows the total unread count across threads.
- New message from the + menu starts a thread with any connection.

4.7 Profiles, verification and moderation

P-1 Student profiles

As a student, my profile carries my course, level, attempt and city so connections, vacancy matches and groups are relevant.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- Onboarding collects course (CA, CMA, CS), level, attempt and city.
- The profile drives vacancy-scan matching and resource defaults.
- Profiles are visible to connections and firms the student applies to.

P-2 Verified professionals and firms

As a student, I can trust that a Mentor or Firm badge means the person or firm was verified.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- Professionals and firms submit proof (membership number, firm registration) for moderator review.
- Verified accounts show a badge everywhere their name appears.
- Only verified firms can post openings.

P-3 Moderation and safety

As any user, I can report or block content and people, and a review queue keeps the community clean.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- Every post, comment, resource and profile offers report; every thread offers block.
- Reports land in an admin review queue with clear resolution states.
- Spam, abusive content and fake job posts are removable by moderators.

5. Non-functional requirements

	Requirement 1
Performance	Cold start under 3s on a mid-range Android; feed first paint under 2s on 4G
Scale	100k registered users and 20k DAU without re-architecture
Availability	99.5% monthly uptime for core reading and messaging
Platforms	Android 9+, iOS 15+, modern web browsers; one share codebase
Security	Phone OTP sign-in, encrypted transport, role-based access, row-level data isolation
Privacy	DPDP Act 2023 compliance: consent, data export and deletion on request
Offline	Downloaded resources and saved daily reads readable without network
Accessibility	44px touch targets, screen-reader labels, dynamic type support
AI safety	Study-scoped guardrails, source-aware answers, rate limits and cost ceilings

6. Monetization options

Not day one. The community comes first; revenue follows once students depend on the app daily. Options, in the order they become viable:

1. Firm-side listings: featured job and articleship posts for verified firms. Employers pay to reach exactly the students they hire; students keep applying free.
2. Premium study packs: curated notes, RTP and MTP compilations and full mock-test series from top mentors, with revenue shared with the mentors.

3. Cohort Pro subscription: unlimited AI assistant use, advanced MCQ analytics and vacancy alerts a day early, for a small monthly fee.

4. Sponsored mentor sessions: firms and coaching brands sponsor free revision marathons inside the app, clearly labeled.

> **Recommendation**
>
> Stay fully free until at least 10k monthly active students, then start with firm-side listings. Charging students before the community is strong would slow the growth the whole product depends on.

7. Roadmap

1. Phase 1, community core (weeks 1-8): onboarding with course and level, Feed with daily reads, Resources with the full course structure, personal messaging, the + create menu. The smallest version worth launching.

2. Phase 2, work and network (weeks 9-14): Work and hiring with applications, firm verification and firm profiles, Community groups, the connections network with badges.

3. Phase 3, ICAI module and AI (weeks 15-20): the ICAI services grid, Cohort AI assistant, MCQ practice with history, vacancy scan and notifications.

4. Phase 4, grow (weeks 21+): events and webinars, moderation tooling at scale, monetization (firm listings first), CMA and CS institute modules to match ICAI.

8. Out of scope for v1

- Payments and paid content inside the app.
- Live classes or video hosting; videos link out to where they are hosted.
- Direct ICAI API integration; v1 deep-links to official ICAI pages instead.
- Group chat; v1 messaging is one-to-one, group chat follows in Phase 4.
- Languages beyond English; Telugu and Hindi support is a later decision.

9. Open questions

- Final name: Cohort is a placeholder. A name check (domain, Play Store, trademark) is needed before launch.
- Vacancy scan sources: which job boards and firm postings feed the scan, and whether firms post directly first.
- Daily reads sourcing: editorial team, mentor submissions or AI-assisted curation with human review.
- CMA and CS modules: whether ICMAI and ICSI services get their own grids in Phase 3 or Phase 4.

- AI provider and budget: which LLM API, and the monthly cost ceiling per active student.

Written 23 Oct 2026 from the feature list, the plan and the working prototype. Sample names, firms and numbers in the prototype are demo content, not real data.